and did spokesman duties, had released a note seeking a ceasefire to consult his peers on brokering a surrender. Devji, effectively the lone surviving politburo member actively taking decisions, vetoed it. Termed a 'traitor', Sonu insisted even Basavaraju had issued a similar appeal before his encounter. Yet, the government had refused, saying there was no war on, though it was open to surrenders.

When he heeded the call, why did Sonu choose Maharashtra, not Chhattisgarh—his area of operation? Sources point to his wife Tarakka, who had laid down arms in Maharashtra in January. The state offers a better severance package for retiring guerrillas. Sonu carried a total reward of Rs 6 crore, adding all the states where he was wanted. For CC members, Maharashtra offers Rs 50 lakh; Chhattisgarh only Rs 40 lakh.

Takeaways

- **Politburo member Bhupathi alias Sonu lays down arms in Maharashtra; top insurgent Satish follows suit in Chhattisgarh. In all, 270 rebels surrender**
- **The two states have rolled out attractive terms for surrender**

The mass surrender in Chhattisgarh is also being linked to Sonu, since he had close ties with Satish and many others who lined before Sai. Bastar IG Sundarraj P. says there were no "peace talks with Maoists in Chhattisgarh, unlike in Andhra Pradesh in 2004". Yet, there was communication. The Maoists would test the waters for peace via a press note every few weeks. Typically, deputy CM Vijay Sharma responded with surrender calls, no strings attached. Anyway, 50 cadres came out of the forests in Koyalibeda in Kanker on October 15; a day later, a 160-strong unit led by Satish emerged on the Dantewada-Bijapur border. On October 17, they came before the CM in Jagdalpur, in a ceremony similar to the one at Gadchiroli.

SINECURE FOR REBELS

Housed in a transit camp for debriefing, the ex-insurgents would be offered jobs commensurate with their education and aptitude—for instance, in the police. Satish, meanwhile, told the media he had been assured there would be no pressure on them to join the District Reserve Guard, the police's sword-arm built around Adivasis, with a fair sprinkling of surrendered Maoists among them. As for the surrender reward, only Rs 50,000 will be released immediately, plus Rs 10,000 for sustenance; the bulk will be stowed away in a bank for three years, a quasi-probation period.

With this, Dandakaranya's 'North Sub Zonal Committee' has mostly folded up and "the movement has considerably weakened in North Bastar's Kanker and part of Abujhmad", says IG Sundarraj. Indeed, the entire Maoist edifice is in dire straits. The politburo had five members at the beginning of 2025. That has dwindled to just three: Ganapathi, Devji, Mishir Besra. Ganapathi is old and ailing, Besra is in charge of Jharkhand. The CC, which had 18 members as 2025 dawned, now has just five.

Still untamed by Chhattisgarh are Bijapur, Sukma and Narayanpur districts, where committed cadres are down to around 250. This includes around 120 of 'Battalion Number 1', once headed by Madvi Hidma, said to be the best trained. The Centre's deadline of March 31, 2026, is not very far. ■



▶ TAMIL NADU

STREETS T

The Stalin regime orders caste-bas

By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

RENAMING HAS TYPICALLY STRUTTED down a different street in India, but Tamil Nadu is all set to change the name of the game. As it marks a century of Periyar's Self-Respect Movement, the state is axing the markers of an older form of pride. Caste-based names will be erased from streets, localities, water bodies and public landmarks across all districts.

An October order stipulates that every municipal body and panchayat will comb through its jurisdictions, identify public spaces carrying caste-linked titles and rename them. The replacements are to be caste-neutral and